

3 Cain

The first son and the first murderer, warned by God that sin was crouching at his door.

Cain was the firstborn of Adam and Eve and the first person born in the Bible. He worked the ground like his father. When God accepted his brother Abel's offering but not his own, Cain grew angry. God warned him that sin was waiting to master him, but Cain killed Abel in the field. Even then, God questioned him, judged him, and protected him from being killed in turn. Cain went out from God's presence, built a city, and fathered a line known for both skill and violence. His story shows how quickly sin grew after Eden, and how God speaks to us before we fall.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Qayin</i> . It sounds like Eve's word "gotten" in Genesis 4:1
Family	Son of Adam and Eve; brother of Abel and Seth; father of Enoch (Genesis 4:1–2, 17)
Work	"A tiller of the ground" (Genesis 4:2)
Key places	The field; the land of Nod, east of Eden; the city he named Enoch (Genesis 4:8, 16–17)
Key people	Adam, Eve, Abel, his son Enoch, his descendant Lamech
Main passages	Genesis 4:1–24
New Testament	Hebrews 11:4; 1 John 3:12; Jude 11

"If thou doest well, shalt thou not be accepted? and if thou doest not well, sin lieth at the door. And unto thee shall be his desire, and thou shalt rule over him."

Genesis 4:7, KJV

The life of Cain

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Cain. The order below follows the text.

After Eden	● Born to Eve Eve bears her first son and says, "I have gotten a man from the LORD." <i>Genesis 4:1</i>
Grown	● Works the ground Abel keeps sheep, "but Cain was a tiller of the ground." <i>Genesis 4:2</i>
Later	● Brings an offering Cain brings fruit of the ground to the LORD. God respects Abel's offering but not Cain's, and Cain's face falls in anger. <i>Genesis 4:3–5</i>
Then	● Warned by God God asks why he is angry and warns that sin is lying at the door, but that he must rule over it. <i>Genesis 4:6–7</i>
In the field	● Kills Abel Cain talks with his brother, and in the field he rises up against Abel and kills him. <i>Genesis 4:8</i>
Afterward	● Judged and marked God asks, "Where is Abel thy brother?" Cain says, "Am I my brother's keeper?" God curses him to be a wanderer. When Cain fears being killed, God sets a mark on him for protection. <i>Genesis 4:9–15</i>
East of Eden	● Settles in Nod Cain goes out from the presence of the LORD to the land of Nod. He fathers Enoch and builds a city named after him. <i>Genesis 4:16–17</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Genesis does not say why God rejected Cain's offering. Some point to the kind of gift; Hebrews 11:4 points to faith. Genesis also does not name Cain's wife. A common view is that she was one of Adam's daughters (Genesis 5:4). Scripture does not say what the mark was.

-
- 1 **Worked the ground.** He took up the work given to Adam after the fall. *Genesis 3:23; 4:2*
 - 2 **Brought an offering.** He brought "of the fruit of the ground" to the LORD, but it was not accepted. *Genesis 4:3–5*
 - 3 **Grew angry.** He was very angry, and his face fell. *Genesis 4:5*
 - 4 **Ignored God's warning.** God urged him to do well and to master sin before it mastered him. *Genesis 4:6–7*
 - 5 **Killed his brother.** He attacked Abel in the field, the first murder in Scripture. *Genesis 4:8*
 - 6 **Denied and dodged.** He lied ("I know not") and asked, "Am I my brother's keeper?" *Genesis 4:9*
 - 7 **Cried out under judgment.** He said, "My punishment is greater than I can bear," and feared for his life. *Genesis 4:13–14*
 - 8 **Built a city.** He fathered Enoch and named a city after him. *Genesis 4:17*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Cain.

Old Testament

Genesis 4:1–16	The whole account of Cain
Genesis 4:17–24	His line, down to boastful, violent Lamech
Genesis 4:25	Seth given "instead of Abel, whom Cain slew"
Echo: Genesis 9:6	Shedding blood forbidden; humans bear God's image

New Testament

Hebrews 11:4	Abel's "more excellent sacrifice than Cain"
1 John 3:12	"Not as Cain, who was of that wicked one"
Jude 11	False teachers "have gone in the way of Cain"
Echo: Matthew 5:21–22	Anger in the heart linked to murder

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God say to Cain before he killed Abel (Genesis 4:6–7)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God protected Cain with a mark?
3. *Apply:* Sin waits at the door. What "doors" in your life need watching?
4. *Apply:* "Am I my brother's keeper?" Who has God given you to care for this week?

Group notes